Lesson 7 — The Bench by the Stairs

Part 1 of 12: Passage — The Bench by the Stairs

Level: B1 (seventh step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-can-and-hafta.mp3` is new — weak can against can't, and have to said as hafta.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. What can you repair yourself, and what must you take to somebody else?
2. What should a person always do before opening a machine?
3. Have you ever had to learn something because nobody else would do it?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Bench by the Stairs (510 words)

The bench is under the stairs in the engineering building, between a window and a cupboard, and it has been there for two years. Two students sit at it on Sunday, Tuesday and Thursday afternoons. Anyone in the college can bring a machine to them, and about half of the machines go away working.

[A] Maysa started it in her second year. She is not an engineer either — she studies information systems — but she had to learn, because nobody else was going to repair the department's laptops and she could not work without one. She can change a screen now in forty minutes. She says the first year was mostly learning what she must not touch.

There is a list of rules taped to the cupboard door, and the first three are about electricity. You must unplug the machine. You must take the battery out if the battery comes out. You must not open a power supply, ever, because a capacitor inside it can hold a charge for days after the plug is pulled, and nothing on this bench is worth that.

[B] After that the rules are about care rather than danger. Put the screwdriver down and touch the metal frame before you touch a component, so that the static on your hands goes somewhere harmless. Put every screw in a labelled box, because the screws are not all the same length and a long one in a short hole will go through something. You do not have to be quick. You do have to be able to put it back together.

Most faults are dull to diagnose, which Maysa says is the good news. A laptop that overheats and shuts down usually has a fan packed with dust; you can clean it with a brush and some air, and it will run for another year. A machine that will not start on battery often needs nothing but a new battery.

[C] Some things cannot be mended at a bench under the stairs, and the second skill is knowing which. A broken screen can be replaced if the part exists. A board with a burnt track cannot, not here. A machine still under warranty should not be opened at all, because opening it ends the warranty. When the answer is no, Maysa writes the reason on a card, because a person who knows why can decide what to do next.

[D] They keep a log. Every machine gets a line: what came in, what they tried, what it needed, whether it worked. The log is how they found out that nine of the last twenty overheating laptops had the same fault, and that they should have checked the fan first every single time.

Samir asked her last month what the bench still needs. She said it must have better light before anything else, that they should have a soldering station, and that they could do twice as much with a second person on Thursdays. "But you can do a great deal," she said, "with a brush and a list of rules."

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Watch the modals as you read: can should be short and quiet, and can't should be long. If they sound the same, slow down and do the paragraph again.